October 7, 2023

NO POINTS. JUST REAL TALK.

Team: Names:

Read the background together. Talk it over as a team, then write your answers. There's no right answer: give reasons, and listen to people who disagree. At the end, your team shares with the class.

BACKGROUND

On October 7, 2023, the holiday of Simchat Torah, Hamas terrorists from Gaza attacked southern Israel. About 1,200 people were killed and 251 were taken hostage into Gaza: the deadliest day for Jews since the Holocaust. Within days, about 360,000 reservists reported for duty, some flying home from the United States. The war in Gaza that followed caused enormous loss of life and destruction there, and it is debated around the world. A ceasefire began in October 2025, and the living hostages came home.

> **Thousands of reservists showed up before they were even called. What makes people volunteer like that? Would you?**

WHAT OUR TEAM THINKS, AND WHY

DID ANYONE ON THE TEAM DISAGREE? WHAT DID THEY SAY?

ONE SENTENCE WE'LL SHARE WITH THE CLASS

Should everyone serve?

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BACKGROUND

For decades, ultra-Orthodox (Haredi) men who study Torah full-time were exempt from the draft. In June 2024, Israel's Supreme Court ruled that the government must draft them like everyone else. It's one of the biggest debates in Israel today.

Should full-time religious students be drafted?

SOME SAY
Everyone should share the burden equally, especially in wartime.

OTHERS SAY
Torah study protects the Jewish people too, and army life clashes with a strictly religious life.

WHAT OUR TEAM THINKS, AND WHY

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Women in combat

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BACKGROUND

Since a law passed in 2000, women can serve in many combat jobs: as pilots, in mixed battalions like Caracal, and in border-defense tank crews, which fought on October 7. Many infantry brigades are still for men only.

Should every unit be open to anyone who passes the tests?

SOME SAY
Equal tests, equal chances: the best person should get the job.

OTHERS SAY
Physical demands and each unit's needs should decide, not fairness alone.

WHAT OUR TEAM THINKS, AND WHY

DID ANYONE ON THE TEAM DISAGREE? WHAT DID THEY SAY?

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Drafted at 18

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BACKGROUND

The United States ended its draft in 1973 and has an all-volunteer military. Israel still drafts most 18-year-olds, and many adults keep serving in the reserves for years.

> **If you lived in Israel, how would you feel about being drafted at 18? What would you gain, and what would you give up?**

WHAT OUR TEAM THINKS, AND WHY

DID ANYONE ON THE TEAM DISAGREE? WHAT DID THEY SAY?

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